(Nitish in July 2017 had broken ties with the RJD and gone back to the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance, or NDA). Though Tejashwi led the closed-door talks with Nitish that led to the revival of the MGB and the formation of its government in August 2022, those in the know claim it was primarily Lalu who broke the ice and strongly backed the idea of JD(U) and RJD coming back together. In fact, a month before the new government took over, Nitish, who was then heading the NDA regime in the state, visited Lalu in a Patna hospital when he suffered a fracture after a fall on the stairs at home. As Lalu was later airlifted to Delhi, Nitish ensured all medical expenses for the former chief minister's treatment at AIIMS were paid from the state exchequer.

So is it just emotion that is driving this camaraderie between the two leaders, whose political rivalry has been the stuff of legend? Not really. Lalu knows the power that the RJD and JD(U) pack together. If Lalu commands the support of the formidable M-Y (Muslim-Yadav) bloc, Nitish has the backing of the Extremely Backward Classes (EBCs), Mahadalits and a few other disadvantaged but politically substantive groups in Bihar. In 2015, the two parties, along with the ally Congress, had cornered 178, or 73 per cent, of Bihar's 243 assembly seats. (Today, along with the Left parties and an Independent MLA, the alliance occupies 160 seats in the assembly, well above the halfway mark of 122.)

The challenge, admits a senior RJD leader who prefers to remain anonymous, is bigger this time. "Narendra Modi is too formidable an opponent to be taken lightly in the general election," he says. "Lalu knows that with Nitish by his side, the alliance can punch well above its weight, but only if they present themselves as a united force." No wonder, the RJD boss is doing everything he can to make sure that the alliance stays unbroken.

Another senior party leader who talked to INDIA TODAY on condition of anonymity says the fact that Lalu can reach out to leaders cutting across the political divide, especially his rapport with the Congress leadership, also stands him in good stead. "From Pappu Yadav, who has been critical of Tejashwi Yadav in the past, to Mukesh Sahni, who stormed out of the RJD alliance in 2020, nobody is off limits for Lalu. If Lalu is present and leads from the front, he will inspire greater confidence than Tejashwi can ever do," the RJD leader concedes.

Though Lalu's return is unlikely to change the status quo within the party, which, for all practical purposes, is being led by Tejashwi, the patriarch's presence will definitely boost its electoral prospects. It has been nearly five decades since Lalu first stepped into the Lok Sabha after winning from Chapra at the age of 29 in 1977. Much has changed in the Indian and Bihar political landscape since then, but not the popularity of this shrewd tactician and mass leader. This, despite convictions in the fodder scam cases, the first of which came in 2013 and saw him lose his Lok Sabha membership.

Of course, there is also his role in Nitish's grand plans of forging Opposition unity at the national level, which gave birth to the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance, or INDIA, in Bengaluru on July 18. From cracking a joke with Rahul Gandhi—when the RJD chief asked the Congress leader to trim his beard and get married—during the first Opposition meet in Patna on June 23, to backing Mamata Banerjee at the Bengaluru meet on the issue of the Congress's and Left's feuds with her ruling Trinamool Congress (TMC) in West Bengal, Lalu has shown he is back in the reckoning with his strategies, wit and wisdom.

On July 17, as the septuagenarian leader reached the Taj West End hotel in Bengaluru for a dinner hosted by Karnataka chief minister Siddaramaiah on the eve of the Opposition meet, a security officer was seen assisting him as he climbed a few stairs. On everything else, though, the patriarch is on a firmer footing, something the Opposition's INDIA and the Grand Alliance back home will need to put up a good fight in 2024. ■

Why Lalu Matters

- Was instrumental in the RJD–JD(U) patch-up; has kept his partymen in check, letting Nitish run the one-year-old Mahagathbandhan government in Bihar unencumbered
- Has a key role to play in Opposition unity at the national level; can reach out to leaders across the political divide, shares a special rapport with the Congress leadership
- A shrewd tactician and mass leader, his popularity has remained by and large intact, despite convictions in the fodder scam cases
- Commands support of the formidable Muslim–Yadav bloc; his presence can boost his party's as well as the alliance's electoral prospects in 2024

WHO STANDS WHERE IN THE BIHAR ASSEMBLY

